called as marketing mix. The marketing tools that are generally accepted as the tools of the marketing mix are the **7P**'s which are product, price, promotion, place, process, physical evidence and participants. They may be applied to food and beverage operations in the following way:

1) **Product:** The product basically consists of tangible and intangible features. The tangible or physical characteristics include all those which the customer sees, eats and enjoys. Examples like the restaurant décor, table arrangements, menu design, portion size, lifecycle, and quality of foods and beverages produced and served. The intangible features of the product are those that satisfy the 'feelings' of the customer like the overall ambience of the restaurant and the attitude of the service staff.

2) **Price:** The price charged by the catering operation is based on its need to achieve profitable sales. The price will vary based on the availability, pricing variables and market segments. Depending on the menu offered whether 'a la carte' or 'table d'hôte' menus, government and service taxes are to be inclusive or exclusive, or discounts can be given to group bookings, or reductions of price for meals if ordered before certain hours can be taken into account.

3) **Promotion:** Promotion is informing the prospective customers about the products in an innovative way either by advertising, or using the different channels of communication like, media, newspapers, display boards or coupons. Discounts in price for more than 10 members visiting restaurant or discount given on showing school or college identity card may be promotional techniques.

4) **Place:** This aspect of marketing mix is concerned with the location of the catering outlet, performance of the food service outlet, acceptability of a particular food in a locality and so on. For E.g.: economical restaurants near industries and colleges and small outlets near busy areas.

5) **Process:** The actual procedures, mechanism and flow of activities by which the service or food is delivered is the process. For E.g.: Seating the guest, taking of food orders, dealing with questions and complaints and getting the customers feedback.

6) **Physical evidence:** Exterior/ interior appearance of the building, restaurant floor plan, décor, lighting, table layout, staff uniform, menu card and menu displays are the physical evidences in the marketing mix.

7) **Participants:** The individual-staff and other personnel with whom the customer interacts with for E.g.: Hostess, restaurant manager, waiter and other customers, are the people involved in the marketing. A waiter is the first person a customer comes in contact with and therefore he is the marketing person in a food service.



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